

Rheas

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Rheiformes
FAMILIES	1 (Rheidae)
SPECIES	2

Although rheas look similar to the ostrich, they are much smaller and have 3 (rather than 2) toes on each foot. The head, neck, and thighs are all covered with feathers, and each wing ends in a claw, which is used to fight predators. When running, rheas use their wings for balance. They occur on

upland and lowland plains in most parts of South America.

CARE OF THE YOUNG
Only the male bird incubates the eggs and watches over the young (lesser rheas are shown here). The female goes off in search of other males.



Rhea americana

Greater rhea



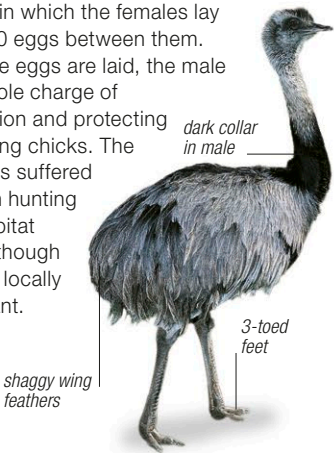
Location E. and S.E. South America



This long-legged, flightless bird lives in grassland and semiarid scrubland. It is generally gray to brown, and white, the plumage offering effective camouflage against tall grass and scrubby vegetation. The male has a dark collar at the base of its neck during the breeding season. A sociable bird, it lives in groups, although breeding

Height 3–5 ft (0.9–1.5 m)
Weight 33–66 lb (15–30 kg)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Near threatened

males are solitary for part of the year. In the mating season, males produce a booming call to attract females, then court them with an impressive wing display. The male mates with up to 12 females and then scrapes out a nest, in which the females lay up to 60 eggs between them. After the eggs are laid, the male takes sole charge of incubation and protecting the young chicks. The rhea has suffered through hunting and habitat loss, although it is still locally abundant.



Cassowaries and Emus

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Casuariiformes
FAMILIES	2
SPECIES	4

These flightless birds have a long neck, long legs, and small wings hidden under loose, hairlike plumage. They are fast runners and can also swim. Cassowaries and emus have 3 toes on each foot; in cassowaries, the innermost toe bears a sharp claw, which can inflict lethal wounds. Cassowaries have a protective casque on their head, and neck wattles that can change color according to the bird's mood.



PATERNAL CARE
The male emu (shown here) does not eat or drink while incubating. After hatching, he cares for the young for up to 8 months.

Casuarus casuarius

Southern cassowary

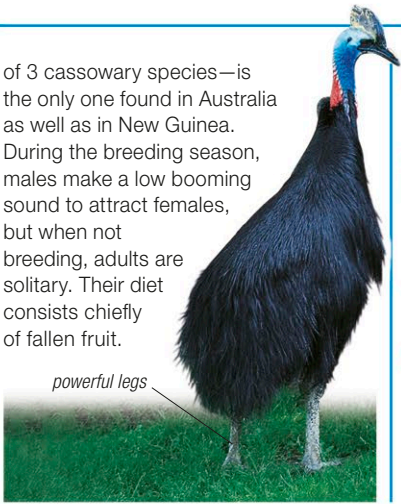


Location New Guinea, N.E. Australia



Height 4¼–5½ ft (1.3–1.7 m)
Weight 37–155 lb (17–70 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Vulnerable

of 3 cassowary species—is the only one found in Australia as well as in New Guinea. During the breeding season, males make a low booming sound to attract females, but when not breeding, adults are solitary. Their diet consists chiefly of fallen fruit.



All cassowaries inhabit dense tropical forest, and as a result are rarely seen. The southern cassowary—the largest

Dromaius novaehollandiae

Emu



Location Australia



Australia's largest native bird, the emu has shaggy, drooping, gray-brown feathers, large legs, but tiny wings. It is highly gregarious, and lives in loose

Height 5–6¼ ft (1.5–1.9 m)
Weight 66–130 lb (30–60 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern

flocks that can contain dozens of birds. It feeds mainly on seeds and berries, and will travel long distances when food is hard to find. Emus are now extinct in Tasmania, but on the Australian mainland, they have benefited from cereal farming, and are now a serious pest in some areas.



Kiwis

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Apterygiformes
FAMILIES	1 (Apterygidae)
SPECIES	5

The strange, flightless kiwis all look much the same. They have a stout body covered in soft, hairlike plumage, a slender, curved bill, and no tail. Unlike larger

flightless birds, kiwis have 4 toes on each foot. These nocturnal birds are native to New Zealand.

SENSES
Although kiwis have poor eyesight, they have acute senses of hearing and smell and a highly touch-sensitive bill.



Apteryx mantelli

North Island brown kiwi



Location New Zealand



Once widespread throughout New Zealand's North Island, this brown bird has been severely affected by deforestation and introduced predators such as pigs, dogs, cats,

and stoats. When feeding, it walks slowly, tapping the ground with its bill and sniffing. It may push its entire bill—up to 6 in (15 cm) long—into the ground to get at food, which consists of earthworms, cicadas, beetle larvae, centipedes, and fallen fruit. Females lay one to 2 eggs that are very large in proportion to the bird's size.

